

Research design worksheet

Capstone projects — fill it in for your own project, and for a classmate's

Dr Noah Buckley

Answer in plain language. If you cannot answer one of these in a sentence or two, that is what to work on next. You will use this twice: for your own project, and to explain a classmate's back to them in workshop 4.

1. **What is your unit of observation?** (Individuals? Leaders? Countries? Provinces, cities, districts? Country-years? Protests? Speeches?)
2. **What is your dependent variable?** Fifteen words or fewer.
3. **What is your independent variable** — the thing that causes a change in your dependent variable? This is your “treatment”, the cause of a change in the world. Fifteen words or fewer.
4. **What variation do you expect to see** in the dependent variable when the independent variable takes different values? What is the difference between “treated” units and “control” units? Two to four sentences.
5. **Is there a mechanism** — an intermediate step — between the independent variable changing and the dependent variable changing? Almost certainly yes. What is it? Put another way: what else has to happen for the effect of X to reach all the way to Y?
6. **How will you measure the independent variable**, in conceptual terms? How will you know whether a unit has been treated? What information about each unit do you need?

7. **What is a treated unit like?** What characteristic distinguishes it from an untreated one?
8. **How will you measure the dependent variable,** in conceptual terms? How will you collect information showing different outcomes for multiple units?
9. **What else could produce the same pattern?** Name one or two alternative explanations and what you would do about them (control for them, choose cases that hold them constant, show they do not fit).
10. **Does X come before Y in time,** in your data or cases? If the independent variable is measured after the outcome moved, something is wrong.